Neal T. Gillespie

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Hiring Committee
Yorba Linda Public Library
4852 Lakeview Avenue
Yorba Linda, CA 92886

Dear Hiring Committee,

I am applying for the Library Clerk position with the Yorba Linda Public Library. The core of this job is running a library system accurately: checking materials in and out, registering patrons, keeping borrower records confidential, and searching bibliographic information. I have not only worked inside systems like that, I have designed and built them, and I would rather be doing this work in a public library than in a fundraising department.

My current title is Direct Mail Production Manager at Young Americans for Liberty, and the materials I manage are printed fundraising pieces: direct mail letters and their reply devices, printed proposals and reports prepared for major donors, inserts, and newsletters. Every piece we produce ends up in a physical archive that I oversee. I take the samples in from the printer, sort and label them, shelve them by campaign and mail code, and pull them when a writer or a director needs a past piece to work from.

When I took that archive over, nothing in it could be found without asking me. I designed a SQL database for the collection, defined a consistent record for every piece covering mail code, campaign, date, format, audience and vendor, and then worked back through several campaign years of material to catalog it against that standard. On top of the database I built a searchable reading room, so staff can query the collection themselves, narrow it by any of those fields, view the scanned copy, and find where the physical original sits on the shelf. That work taught me what a record has to contain to stay findable, which is most of what careful circulation work is protecting.

I have built two more systems on my own time, both of them public websites. The Free Knowledge Library is a digital library of political literature drawn from across the ideological spectrum. I designed the site, the database behind it and the classification scheme, and I built the catalog that readers search. StateTrack is a website that publishes state campaign finance records for all fifty states, where the work was again a schema, an ingest process, and a search interface an ordinary visitor can actually use. Between the two I have spent a great many hours on the question this role turns on, which is whether a record was entered well enough that somebody else can find it later.

Before my current role I was Development Manager at the University of Austin, where part of my work was the campus library. The university was assembling a small library largely from donated books, and I handled the intake side of it: receiving collections as they arrived, documenting what was in them, processing them onto the shelves, and recording the gift. The one I remember best was a complete set of the *Harvard Classics*. I was also the person who walked visitors through that library and answered their questions about the collection.

On the public-facing side, I staffed the registrar service window at Chapman University’s Fowler School of Law as the first person students talked to. That meant assisting people in person and by phone, explaining procedures that were not obvious, handling confidential records, and processing more than five hundred transcripts and exam documents accurately. Fast desk work under a fixed procedure is familiar to me, as is the discretion borrower records require.

I should say plainly that I am able to relocate. I have family in Southern California who can host me during an interim move, which makes getting out there straightforward. I can work a regularly scheduled weekend day and evening hours, including a 9/80 schedule.

I have begun the ALA’s Library Support Staff Certification and begin a Library and Information Services certificate at Central Community College in the spring, with a master’s in library and information science to follow. Thank you for your consideration, and I would welcome the chance to talk.

Sincerely,

Neal T. Gillespie